

price of letting the browser extension collect data about your browsing habits which it can then sell to third parties.

STALKER FOR HIRE

While we don't see any reason why you'd want to hire a stalker in real life, there is the option for you to do just that for gadgets. They're called price trackers. While the previous section covered websites that provided price comparison services, the data shown over there is real-time i.e. you don't get historical information. How can you tell whether a deal is really good or not? A lot of e-commerce websites hike prices across the board for a few days right before sales so that when you do check the product listing again during the day of the sales, it seems that you're getting a massive discount.



Price trackers collect the prices of gadgets on a periodic basis. This could be on a daily basis or even every couple of hours. The information is then presented to you in the form of an easy to read chart. This way, you know how much the product was initially listed for, whether it regularly goes on sale, and if at all it does go on sale then how much of a discount can you expect? Let's say that you're eyeing a gaming mouse that is currently priced at INR 6000. Using a price tracker, you could see that it regularly gets an INR 1000 discount and during shopping festival sales, the price could drop down to as low as INR 3000. Now, it's up to you to decide whether to wait for a 1000 buck discount sale or a 3000 buck discount festival sale. After all, the sticker price is for suckers.

Price History and Keepa are two

good services in this department. Keepa continues to be a reliable service for tracking price on Amazon and even has the option of sending alerts, however, the service is paid if you want to hunt for deals properly. It has a browser extension that works on Amazon but that only gives historical pricing. Price History is an Indian service that tracks prices on popular Indian e-commerce portals but its app is very finicky. When it works, it works great.

TRICKS OF THE TRADE

When you're shopping out there in the real world, there are certain tricks that always help. Not all of them are applicable online. We all know that there's no bargaining on Amazon, Flipkart or any of the other e-commerce stores. However, you can walk away. Surprised? Don't be. Let's say you've spent a couple of minutes shortlisting items on a website. Perhaps, you can favourite them, copy and save the links on your PC or smartphone or you could just add them all to the shopping cart for now. What happens when you don't complete the purchase after adding the items to the shopping cart? On a smartphone, you'll soon get a notification. Whereas on PC, you could get a push notification in your browser or an email stating that you've forgotten to complete your order. Just open the email or notification and close the app again. Wait for a few hours or even days.



The e-commerce website might offer you a small discount on the items in your cart. This could come in the form of an email or a lightning deal notification. These are simply the customer retention mechanisms at play. There are several such mechanisms

running on e-commerce websites to help them make more sales. Enough about gadgets, let's say you want to book tickets for an upcoming trip and you've been hunting for deals on tickets. Trip booking websites often store cookies on your browser with information about the trips that you searched for and the price that you were quoted. When you visit similar websites, those websites can use this information to show you an adjusted discount which isn't the best deal but is only slightly cheaper than the previous website. You can counter this by using incognito mode on your web browser. This way the website can't figure out what deals were shown to you previously, and it shows you the best price that it can offer.

INSTAGRA-TIFICATION

Shopkeepers have realised that the youth prefer to spend most of their time on social media apps and in some countries, these apps have formed walled gardens and for the users, these platforms are the Internet. So shopkeepers have started opening up store tabs on their social media pages. Often, the store fees for social media apps is way lesser than what Amazon or Flipkart would charge. Instagram for example, charges 5 per cent or a flat fee if the product is cheap. Amazon, on the other hand, has closing fees, referral fees, weight handling fees and additional fees. Depending on which of the following works out for the seller, they might choose to list solely on Amazon or Instagram or both. Amazon charges those fees because they offer services that social media websites cannot and Amazon has the might to scale a business operation. So there are a lot of small businesses that sell solely on Instagram when starting off. The money saved can end up as an additional discount for you.

Whether you're shopping for a gadget online or planning a short trip with your significant other, these handy tricks are certain to save you money. Our next story deals with everything that you can do to take care of your recently purchased gadgets. Off you go... 